



The main colonnade at Palmyra, which grew rich on tariffs paid by merchants who plied the desert route that passed through the Syrian city.



SHAPUR I (d.272)

Shapur's early leadership experience came in a role assisting his father, Ardashir, in mopping up support for the Parthian Arsacid dynasty. Shapur's defeats of Gordian III in 244 and of Valerian in 260 established a temporary Persian dominance in Syria and Mesopotamia. He used the many Roman prisoners captured in 256 at Antioch to build the new town of Veh Antiok Shapur ("Shapur's town, better than Antioch").

Goths ravaged the province of Moesia, laying siege to the main town of Nicopolis (modern Nikopol, Bulgaria). The campaign went badly for the Romans, ending in defeat and Decius's death at the **Battle of Abrittus** in 251.

In Japan, the **Yamato kingdom** emerged on the plain of Nara (in central Japan) around 250. Its rulers were interred in large burial mounds, and its armies conquered most of central Japan. Much of what is known comes from Chinese sources, who name the Queen of Yamato in 238 as **Himiko**.

VALERIAN'S CAPTURE BY THE PERSIANS in 260 proved disastrous for the western part of the Roman Empire as well as the east. Valerian's son **Gallienus** (r. 260–68), struggling to contain an invasion of Italy by the Germanic **luthungi** had no resources to reinforce the Rhine frontier, which was being breached by **Alemanni** and **Frankish raiders**. The Governor of Germania Inferior, **Marcus Postumus**, revolted and killed Gallienus's son Saloninus, who had been left in charge of Gaul and

The Gallic Empire

Postumus began the Gallic Empire in control of Gaul, Germany, Britain, and Spain. By its collapse in 274, the last ruler, Tetricus, had lost Spain.

Germany. Postumus **declared himself emperor**, but unlike previous usurpers did not march on Rome, instead setting up a separate **Gallic Empire**; this initially controlled Britain, Spain, parts of western Germany, and Gaul. He established a form of government that mirrored that of the official empire, complete with its own Senate. In 269, Postumus was murdered by his own troops and replaced by his praetorian prefect Victorinus. Gallienus—faced with **Gothic invasions** and the revolt of **Zenobia of Palmyra** in the east—was **never strong enough** to put an end to the Gallic Empire. In 268 he was murdered by the army and replaced by Claudius II Gothicus (r. 268–70), who was too busy fighting in the

Balkans to deal with Gaul. Only under **Aurelian** (r. 270–74) was the Roman Empire strong enough, and by then the Gallic Empire was weakened, with its last ruler, Tetricus (r. 270–74), facing splits in the army. In 274, Tetricus was captured near Châlons, and the **Gallic Empire was reabsorbed**.

In the east, a serious **challenge to Roman rule** emerged after 260. The city of **Palmyra** (in Syria) proved Rome's **only reliable ally** against the Sasanian advances of Persia. Its ruler **Septimius Odaenathus** (c. 220–67) received a number of Roman titles, including *Corrector Totius Orientis* ("Marshal of the entire East"), and invaded the Sasanian Empire in 262 and 266. Odaenathus died in 267; and his wife **Zenobia** (r. 267–73) created **an empire of her own**. By 269, her armies had taken Syria and Egypt, and in 271 she declared her son **Vaballathus** emperor.

Aurelian marched east and soon rolled back the Palmyrene gains, besieging Palmyra in spring 272. Zenobia was captured while trying to escape, and Palmyra was sacked in 273 when it tried to throw off Roman rule again.



Sepulchral relief from Palmyra

The Palmyrenes buried their dead with exquisite and realistic personal portrayals; the dead were interred in tower tombs outside the city.

In China, **Yuandi** (r. 260–64) restored Wei's fortunes by conquering the Shu Han. But soon after he was overthrown by one of his own generals, **Sima Yuan**, who founded the **Western Jin** dynasty and took the title Wudi (r. 265–89). His armies crushed and annexed the Wu kingdom in 280, thus **briefly reuniting China**.



“YOU DEMAND MY SURRENDER AS THOUGH YOU WERE NOT AWARE THAT CLEOPATRA PREFERRED TO DIE A QUEEN RATHER THAN REMAIN ALIVE.”

Zenobia, Queen of Palmyra, to Aurelian Augustus from *Historia Augusta* c. 375–400

257 Decius issues edict forbidding Christian worship

260 Shapur I defeats Valerian and takes him prisoner; Gallienus declared Roman emperor

260 Breakaway Gallic Empire established by Postumus

258 Martyrdom of Cyprian, Bishop of Carthage

265 Western Jin dynasty takes over the territory formerly ruled by the Wei

267 Massive Gothic incursion into Thrace, Macedonia, and Greece

267 Murder of Odaenathus of Palmyra; Syria, a former Roman ally

267 Odaenathus's widow Zenobia comes to power in Palmyra, revolts against Rome and takes much of Asia Minor

269 Emperor Claudius II wins major victory against the Goths at Naissus

271 Roman emperor Aurelian orders the evacuation of Dacia; he recovers Egypt for Rome

271 Zenobia has her son, Vaballathus, declared emperor

273 Aurelian suppresses the revolt of Palmyra

274 Tetricus defeated by Aurelian; the Gallic Empire is reunited with the Roman Empire

275 Murder of Aurelian; he is succeeded by Tacitus

275 Franks and Alamanni again ravage Gaul

275 St. Anthony retreats to a solitary desert life, near the site of his future monastery